

Weekly Business Session: September 23, 2026

9:00 a.m. - Anne G. Basker Auditorium, 600 N.W. Sixth St, Grants Pass, Oregon

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair; Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

2. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:

a. AMR Rate Increase

Dave Matthews, Operations Manager for American Medical Response (AMR) Northwest, presented a requested 10% rate increase and mileage adjustment effective October 1, 2026. He stated the increase is intended to address labor and other inflationary operating costs. Medicare, Medicaid and facility-responsible patients would not be affected by the increase; the impact would fall primarily on third-party payers. Mr. Matthews reviewed comparative ambulance rates, staffing, equipment, clinical programs, community outreach, disaster preparedness and the \$55 annual Paramed membership program. He stated the requested increase is expected to generate approximately \$154,117.

3. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS

Judy Ahrens, Josephine County, spoke about public education, Constitution Day, civic education and the importance of students learning about the United States Constitution and American history.

Mark Jones, Josephine County, raised concerns regarding increases in manufactured-home park space rents and the effect on elderly residents, including difficulties selling homes when prospective buyers cannot meet income requirements tied to higher space rent. He asked the Board to explore whether the County could take any action to protect affected seniors.

4. BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS

The Board discussed the AMR request and the effect of fixed Medicare and Medicaid reimbursement rates on ambulance service costs. Mr. Matthews responded to questions regarding typical transport costs and third-party insurance. Commissioners also responded to the public comments concerning education and manufactured-home park rents. The Board expressed interest in receiving additional information regarding the manufactured-home issue, and Chair Smith stated he would consult Legal Counsel regarding what options, if any, may be available to the County.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve the AMR Rate Increase. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon Roll call: Commissioner Richardson – Yes. Commissioner Martin – Yes. Commissioner Smith – Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

5. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR

Minutes (draft minutes are available for viewing in the board's office):

Admin Workshop – September 15, 2026

Weekly Business Session – September 16, 2026

Legal Counsel Update – September 17, 2026

Commissioner Richardson moved to approve the Consent Calendar. Commissioner Smith seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

6. OTHER MATTERS: (ORS 192.640(1) ...Commissioners may introduce other matters for consideration by the entire board)

Commissioner Richardson deferred his item to Announcements. Commissioner Martin had no other matters. Chair Smith stated he was thankful Josephine County was nearing the end of fire season without a catastrophic large wildfire.

7. ANNOUNCEMENTS

Commissioner Richardson displayed a ceremonial shovel from the September 10, 1974 groundbreaking for the law enforcement/courts addition and discussed his connection to former Commissioner Ann Basker and her involvement in local flood-control projects. Commissioner Martin noted that Ann Basker was the first woman to serve as a Josephine County Commissioner. Chair Smith had no additional announcements.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:31 a.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder